

U1L6SP — Short Paper 1

Prophecy Is Not Proof?

Week 6: Validity, Truth, and Soundness

Name: _____

Date: _____

The question

In *Macbeth*, the witches tell Macbeth that he “shalt be king hereafter.” Does this prophecy give Macbeth a sound reason to take action toward becoming king, or does it only tell him what may happen? Make and defend your own judgment.

You may answer *yes*, *no*, or *partly*. A successful paper is not the one that guesses the teacher’s answer. It is the one whose conclusion is earned by its reasons and evidence.

Two lines to keep in view

The witches: “All hail, Macbeth, that shalt be king hereafter!” (1.3)

Macbeth: “If chance will have me king, why, chance may crown me, / Without my stir.” (1.3)

You may use other details from the play, but you do not need outside research.

The assignment

Write a short paper of **one to two handwritten pages** on separate lined paper. Give it the title *Prophecy Is Not Proof?* Your paper should:

- answer the question with a clear claim;
- explain the reasoning that could connect the prophecy to action;
- test whether the conclusion really follows, even if the prophecy is true;
- use at least two brief quotations or exact details from *Macbeth*;
- end with a careful judgment, including any limit or qualification your answer needs.

You do not need a five-paragraph essay. A clear beginning, a developed middle, and an honest ending are enough.

The closed-world rule

This paper must come from **you**. You may use only your copy of *Macbeth*, course handouts, and notes you made during class.

Do not use AI, the internet, online summaries, outside criticism, a tutor, a parent, a friend, or anyone else’s sentences or ideas. Do not ask another person to plan, revise, or correct the paper. If you are uncertain, write through the uncertainty yourself. That struggle is part of the assignment.

At the end of your paper, write and sign: *I wrote this paper without outside help.*

What counts on this first paper — 10 points

Claim	Gives a definite answer to the question.	2
Logical work	Identifies and tests the reasoning between prophecy and action.	3
Textual evidence	Uses at least two accurate quotations or details.	2
Explanation	Connects the evidence to the claim instead of merely retelling the plot.	2
Completion	Is legible, handwritten, and within the assigned length.	1

This is a practice paper. Honest reasoning matters more than polish. Spelling and grammar will not lower the score unless they prevent the reader from understanding the argument.

Planning Scaffold

U1L6SP — Use this page before writing

This page helps you think; it does not choose your answer. Notes and fragments are enough. Your final paper goes on separate lined paper.

1. Your present answer

In one sentence, what do you currently think the prophecy gives Macbeth a reason to do—or not to do?

2. Reconstruct the reasoning

What claim does the prophecy make?

What action or conclusion might Macbeth draw from it?

What unstated bridge would be needed to move from the prophecy to that action?

3. Run both Week 6 tests

Form test: If the relevant claims were true, would the proposed action or conclusion have to follow? Why or why not?

Fact test: Which claim, interpretation, or assumption most needs proof?

4. Choose your evidence

Quotation or exact detail 1:

What it helps you show:

Quotation or exact detail 2:

What it helps you show:

5. Make the judgment careful

What might a reasonable reader say against your answer?

What word such as *because*, *unless*, *although*, *only*, or *partly* could make your claim more accurate?

6. Simple writing path

1. State your answer and name the reasoning problem.
2. Explain the possible bridge from prophecy to action.
3. Test that bridge with the play's evidence.
4. Give your qualified final judgment.

7. Try your opening

Draft two or three possible opening sentences. State your present answer and name the reasoning you will test. You may change these sentences when you write the paper.

8. Details not to forget

Record any final words, quotations, or ideas you want beside you while writing.

Before submitting: Underline your main claim once. Circle the two places where you use evidence from the play.